

“The US must either make Diem reform or **get rid of him.**”

BUDDHIST MONK TRI QUANG, 1963

Pagoda raids

The unrest continued. It spread to Saigon, where, on May 30, 500 Buddhist monks staged a sit-down street demonstration against the regime. Four days later another protest was forcibly dispersed by Diem's security police. Then, on June 11, Thich Quang Duc, a 73-year-old monk, publicly burned himself to death at a major city intersection. Over the coming weeks, six other monks and nuns followed his example. The protests gathered momentum, with high school and university students taking a leading role.

On August 21, Nhu acted. Shortly after midnight, truckloads of his personal security police, disguised as soldiers, surrounded the Xa Loi Pagoda, Saigon's principal Buddhist shrine. They ransacked the building and arrested some 400 monks and nuns. In Hue, monks barricaded themselves inside the Dieu De Temple for eight hours before surrendering. More than 1,400 were arrested across the country.



Mass protest

Protesters try to tear down a barbed wire barricade with their bare hands as they are confronted by the police at Giac Minh pagoda on July 17, 1963. Hundreds of monks, nuns, and laypeople were kicked, punched, and clubbed by police in the Cholon district of Saigon.

Dire consequences